THE RACE TO PO

The BJP and the ruling TMC are competing with each other for

BJP

- **VHP and BJP claim to have hosted Ram Mahotsav events in over 100,000 locations in 2025, took out around 2,000 rallies on Ramnavami**
- **Principal Opposition BJP continually accuses the TMC of 'minority appeasement' and being 'anti-Hindu'**
- **BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari said in the assembly that Muslim MLAs of the TMC would be "dragged on to the streets" if the BJP came to power in 2026**
- **RSS, with its grassroots reach in Bengal, is gearing up to mobilise increased turnout of Hindu voters in 2026**
- **Protests against violence in Murshidabad used to further polarise communities**

BSF, and two or three political parties," claiming that miscreants were allowed to run amok and then escape unscathed. The suggestion seems to be that the carnage involved some spontaneous violence, as well as an element of politically engineered, and harvested, chaos.

TEMPLE POLITICS

The violence in Murshidabad and elsewhere has to be seen in light of the game of competitive communalism that the TMC and the BJP are playing as they prepare for the electoral showdown next year. Religious symbolism, once peripheral to Bengal's political grammar, has moved centrestage. Temples are now political statements, and festivals potent tools of mobilisation.

Since its ascent in 2011, the TMC largely adhered to the secular fabric of the erstwhile Left regime. It enjoyed robust support among minorities, who make up nearly 27 per cent of the state's population. Its response to the BJP's accusations of "minority appeasement" and "anti-Hindu" governance were once met with indifference. All that changed in 2019, when the BJP captured 18 out of the state's 42 Lok Sabha seats, clinching 57 per cent of the Hindu vote. Changing tack, the TMC's Hindu outreach expanded visibly. Mamata herself began flaunting her Hindu Brahmin identity. A stipend scheme originally started for imams in 2012 was extended to Hindu priests. Varanasi's famed Ganga aarti was replicated on the banks of the Hooghly. Plans for temples—replicas of Puri's Jagannath and Vaishno Devi—were announced. The Rs 250 crore replica of the Jagannath temple in Digha is set to be inaugurated on April 30, the day of Akshaya Tritiya, an auspicious day in the Hindu calendar. Not to be outdone, the BJP's Suvendu Adhikari has vowed to build a Ram temple in Nandigram; the foundation stone was laid on Ramnavami.

Ramnavami, in fact, has been converted into a statewide phenomenon by the BJP, alongside its affiliate Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP) and its ideological parent, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS). From a subdued ritual a decade ago, it has now morphed into a cultural juggernaut in the state. In 2025 alone, around 2,000 rallies were held, with Ram Mahotsavs claimed to have been held in over 100,000 locations. "The misrule of the Trinamool Congress has brought together the Hindu community," says BJP's Samik Bhattacharya. "Their protests are being translated into Ramnavami and Hanuman Jayanti rallies."

The TMC has responded in kind. Ramnavami processions are now led by its own leaders. In Nabadweep and Purulia, TMC-run municipalities urged butcher shops to remain shut during Holi and Ramnavami. "Our Ram is peaceful," said TMC MP Partha Bhowmick, stressing that TMC leaders had always been part of such rallies. "The BJP wants to impose a foreign culture that teaches children to wield swords."



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

Even as this year's Ramnavami passed without incident, earlier years have provided enough of a volatile record: communal unrest erupted in Raniganj in 2018, in Asansol in 2019, in Howrah in 2022 and 2023, and in Murshidabad just last year.

ANALYSTS SAY THAT THE BJP, EMBOLDENED BY ITS 38.73 PER CENT VOTE SHARE IN 2024, IS AIMING FOR A 7-8 PER CENT SWING IN 2026. THE INCREASED TURNOUT OF HINDU VOTERS IS KEY TO ITS REALISATION